

As shown in Table 6.1.4, data from the Censuses of Population and Housing between 1946 and 2024 reveal significant shifts in age structure of Sri Lanka across five-year age groups. During the 35-year period from 1946 to 1981, the elderly population (aged 60 and over) increased by only 1.1 percentage points, rising from 5.5 percent to 6.6 percent. However, in the short span of 12 years between 2012 and 2024, this figure grew remarkably by 5.6 percentage points, from 12.4 percent to 18.0 percent. According to the 2024 census data, 18 out of every 100 persons in Sri Lanka are now over the age of 60. Similarly, the percentage of the youngest segment, the new addition to the population (ages 0–4) has more than halved, dropping from 12.9 percent in 1946 to 5.6 percent in 2024.

Table 6.1.4 : Percentage Distribution of Population by Age Group, 1946–2024

Age Group	Census Year							
	1946	1953	1963	1971	1981	2001*	2012	2024
Sri Lanka	100.0	100.0	100.0	100.0	100.0	100.0	100.0	100.0
00-04	12.9	14.9	15.2	13.1	12.5	8.5	8.6	5.6
05-09	12.2	13.4	13.7	13.2	11.3	8.8	8.6	7.1
10-14	12.1	11.4	12.6	12.7	11.4	9.0	8.1	8.0
15-19	10.2	8.7	9.7	10.7	10.8	9.7	8.1	8.1
20-24	9.6	9.5	8.4	10.0	10.2	9.4	7.5	7.4
25-29	8.7	8.8	7.0	7.5	8.6	7.9	7.6	6.3
30-34	6.8	6.4	6.3	5.8	7.6	7.6	8.1	6.5
35-39	7.0	6.6	6.2	5.7	5.7	7.4	6.9	6.7
40-44	4.8	4.6	4.6	4.6	4.7	6.9	6.7	7.4
45-49	4.8	4.6	4.3	4.3	4.1	6.1	6.3	6.8
50-54	3.0	3.4	3.4	3.3	3.6	5.4	6.0	6.2
55-59	2.5	2.3	2.6	2.8	2.8	4.0	5.2	5.9
60 and over	5.5	5.4	6.0	6.3	6.6	9.2	12.4	18.0

*18 Districts only.

Note: Percentages have been rounded to the nearest decimal place

According to the Census of Population and Housing 2024, the population aged 18 and over is reported as 16,188,496, while the population below the age of 18 stands at 5,593,304. The distribution of this population by sex, sector, and district is presented in the following Table 6.1.5.